



Acts 7:9-16

Jesus In: The Rejected Son

Intro:

Last week, as we began Stephen's response to the religious leaders, we saw that he was not simply retelling Israel's history. Through the story of Abraham, Stephen showed us how God gave a promise that ultimately pointed forward to Jesus. As Stephen continues, he now turns to Joseph, and once again, there is more happening than a simple history lesson. Through Joseph, we begin to see a pattern that God established throughout Israel's history and that would also ultimately find its fulfillment in Christ: *the servant chosen by God is rejected by his own, suffers at their hands, is exalted by God, and becomes the means through which God brings salvation to His people.* Joseph is one of the clearest examples of this pattern. The beloved son was rejected by his own brothers, yet God exalted him and used him to save the very family that had rejected him. And this is not only pointing us forward to Jesus; Stephen is also preparing an accusation against the men standing before him. Israel had repeatedly rejected those whom God had chosen, and **now they had rejected the One to whom they all pointed.**

V.9-10

“*And the patriarchs, jealous of Joseph, sold him into Egypt; but God was with him and rescued him out of all his afflictions and gave him favor and wisdom before Pharaoh, king of Egypt, who made him ruler over Egypt and over all his household.*”

1. Rejected

Joseph was the beloved son of his father (Genesis 37:3) to whom God had given dreams that he would one day rule over his brothers. Yet rather than receiving him, his brothers hated him for it (Genesis 37:8). The one who was loved by his father and chosen for a position of authority was rejected by his own brothers. Stephen specifically tells us that their rejection was motivated by **jealousy**. Their jealousy led them to sell Joseph into Egypt, beginning a period of tremendous suffering in his life. The beloved son became a slave, was falsely accused, and eventually became a prisoner. Yet God's hand was on Joseph and He had chosen him and set Him apart for a special purpose. And in Joseph, we begin to see a shadow of a greater Rejected Son. At Jesus' baptism, the Father declared in *Matthew 3:17*, “*This is my beloved Son, with whom I am well pleased.*” Yet John 1:11 tells us, “*He came to his own, and his own people did not receive him.*” Even the motive behind His rejection is the same as in Joseph's story. Mark 15:10 tells us that Pilate knew “*it was out of envy that the chief priests had delivered him up.*”

2. Exalted

The rejection of Joseph was not the end of his story. Though humanly speaking, everything seemed to be moving farther away from what God had revealed through Joseph's dreams, suddenly, God reverses everything. The prisoner is brought before Pharaoh, God gives him wisdom and favor, and the man his brothers rejected is made ruler over Egypt (Gen. 41:40-41). The brothers had once mocked Joseph, saying, “*Are you indeed to reign over us?*” (Genesis 37:8). Yet in Genesis 42:6, those same brothers come before Joseph and “*bowed themselves before him with their faces to the ground.*” The very thing they resisted was the very thing God accomplished. Joseph's brothers intended to prevent his dreams from being fulfilled, but the very act through which they rejected him became the means God sovereignly used for Joseph to arrive in Egypt.

And again, the pattern points us forward to Christ. Jesus was rejected, humiliated, and crucified, but rejection and death were not the end of His story. Philipians 2:8-9 says, “*He humbled himself by becoming obedient to the point of death, even death on a cross. Therefore God has highly exalted him.*” Peter says similarly in Acts 2:32-33, “*This Jesus God raised up... Being therefore exalted at the right hand of God...*” Joseph was rejected by men and then exalted to rule; Jesus was rejected and crucified by men, raised from the dead, and

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exalted as Lord. But Joseph's exaltation was not simply about his own vindication. God exalted Joseph for a saving purpose.

V.11-16

*"Now there came a famine throughout all Egypt and Canaan, and **great affliction**, and our fathers could find no food. But when Jacob heard that there was grain in Egypt, he sent out our fathers on their first visit. And on the second visit Joseph made himself known to his brothers, and Joseph's family became known to Pharaoh. And **Joseph sent and summoned Jacob his father and all his kindred, seventy-five persons in all**. And Jacob went down into Egypt, and he died, he and our fathers, and they were carried back to Shechem and laid in the tomb that Abraham had bought for a sum of silver from the sons of Hamor in Shechem."*

3. Savior

Now Stephen shows us why God had sovereignly placed Joseph in Egypt. A famine comes upon Egypt and Canaan, and Jacob's family cannot find food. Their lives are in danger, and the very brother they had rejected is now the one God has placed in a position to preserve them. **The rejected son has been exalted, and through his exaltation God brings salvation to the very family that rejected him.** Years later, Joseph explains the entire story to his brothers in Genesis 50:20: *"As for you, you meant evil against me, but God meant it for good, to bring it about that many people should be kept alive, as they are today."* Joseph does not deny their sin. They meant evil against him. Yet at the same time, God was sovereignly accomplishing His good purpose through what they had done.

But Joseph was just an instrument and shadow of the true Savior who would come. Jesus is the true Savior who Joseph was foreshadowing. Acts 5:30–31 brings the entire pattern together: **"The God of our fathers raised Jesus, whom you killed by hanging him on a tree. God exalted him at his right hand as Leader and Savior, to give repentance to Israel and forgiveness of sins."** Just as Joseph was rejected and exalted to become the means through which God preserved the lives of his family. Jesus was rejected, crucified, raised, and exalted as the Savior who gives repentance, forgiveness, and eternal life to His people.

Conclusion and Main idea:

Read: Mathew 21:33-46. This is the pattern Stephen is beginning to expose. **Joseph was rejected by his brothers, yet God exalted him. Later, Israel would continue rejecting those whom God sent, until finally they rejected the Son Himself.** Stephen's audience knew these stories. Their problem was not that they did not know what Joseph's brothers had done; their problem was that they could recognize that they were repeating the same pattern themselves. Stephen will eventually tell them plainly in Acts 7:51, *"As your fathers did, so do you."*

And that is where Stephen's message confronts us as well. *The danger is that we can become very good at recognizing sinful patterns in Scripture and in others while remaining blind to those same patterns of rejection in ourselves.* We can see the jealousy of Joseph's brothers, the unbelief of Israel, and the hardness of the religious leaders while refusing to see our own pride, jealousy, unbelief, or resistance to what God has said. So the question this passage leaves us with is not, "Who has rejected me like Joseph?" The question is, *"Where am I repeating this sinful pattern and rejecting God's Lordship in my life?"* Because this story ultimately leaves us with good news. Joseph's brothers rejected him, but God exalted him and through him preserved their lives. Jesus was rejected and crucified, **but he has risen from the dead and now is the exalted king who though we rejected and betrayed Him, now offers us salvation through faith in Him. The Rejected Son, who has been exalted, became the Savior of those who rejected Him.**

